

KNOLLSY

Chris Knoll THE West Ham fan
by Catalina Brown

Chris, thank you for agreeing to talk to me about West Ham.

That's all right, not a problem, it's one of my favourite subjects!

So, how long have you been a West Ham fan?

Since about 1978. So, when I was 13 I started going to West Ham, it's quite a feat really because I didn't go with anybody. I think to the best of my knowledge, I was the only West Ham fan in the whole of the school so really I used to go by myself all the way on the train up to the old ground.

How did you become one, is anyone else in your family a West Ham fan?

All my family from now on are West Ham fans, I've got three girls and a boy, the boy isn't really interested in football but the three girls are West Ham fans. The youngest one, she goes with me, she's a season ticket holder as am I. To answer your question sorry, I sort of went off the track a little bit there. When we were kids we would play football outside and I remember there were a bunch of Tottenham lads and they were a bit older than us and they would bully us about a bit. When we beat them, one of the bigger lads came up to me and said 'you know you're quite a good footballer aren't you?', I went 'yeah,

I'm okay', and he went 'who do you support?'. I said 'I don't support anybody' and he said, 'you've got to support a football team' and I said 'well how do you decide what team you support?'. And I remember him saying to me it's got to be either where you live or where your mum and dad were from. I walked into the house and I asked my mum where she was brought up and she said Hackney Wick and I just asked her what the nearest football team was and she said West Ham United and that was it. I was a West Ham fan from there on in.

You said your mum's from Hackney Wick, right? Would you say Hackney Wick has tied itself to West Ham in some way?

I think it's the other way around really, I think West Ham have tied themselves to Hackney Wick because up until 2006 we were at a different stadium. I think West Ham are embracing Hackney. I know Hackney Wick from old because there was a film studio called 3 Mill Studios, I did two pretty big jobs there and I used to go to Hackney Wick to socialize at lunchtime. It's changed since West Ham arrived. A lot of the bars to start off with were, I wouldn't say they were anti West Ham, but I don't think they particularly wanted the football culture in there, you know you weren't allowed into the bars with shirts on. Some places, I don't know why, would only serve West Ham fans before the game. All that is beginning to change, I think everyone's decided that, okay this is really good for the area you know it brings in a decent amount of money.

What would you say is special about being a West Ham fan?

West Ham really is like an extended family you know, they take you in. As you know I've had something happen to me this year where I've sort of been thrown into the forefront of a few papers. Walking into West Ham it's almost like yeah everybody knows you and everybody has respect for you and it's just like a big extended family really, it's where I feel comfortable.

I guess lastly, what do you hope for the future of West Ham?

Long-term, you know football is sort of money orientated. You've got the bigger clubs that have got the big sponsors. You've got Man City that have got Etihad, you've got Newcastle which have Saudi investors and prior to that you had Chelsea which was backed by Roman Abramovich. I hope that that will happen to West Ham one day and I'll tell you for why, because we're a unique part of London. We're not central London, where you've got Tottenham and Arsenal or West London where you've got Chelsea, Fulham and Brentford. Here, over east you've got nobody and we're a unique area and a unique culture you know, we're East London.